

WEEK 17

SUNDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 8: 22 – 34, 54 – 61*

Prayer of Solomon in the dedication of the Temple.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Then Solomon stood before the altar of the LORD in the presence of all the assembly of Israel, and spread forth his hands toward heaven; and said, "O LORD, God of Israel, there is no God like you, in heaven above or on earth beneath, keeping covenant and showing steadfast love to your servants who walk before you with all their heart; who have kept with your servant David my father what you did declare to him; yes, you did speak with your mouth, and with your hand have fulfilled it this day. Now therefore, O LORD, God of Israel, keep with your servant David my father what you have promised him, saying, 'There shall never fail you a man before me to sit upon the throne of Israel, if only your sons take heed to their way, to walk before me as you have walked before me.' Now therefore, O God of Israel, let your word be confirmed, which you have spoken to your servant David my father.

"But will God indeed dwell on the earth? Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you; how much less this house which I have built! Yet have regard to the prayer of your servant and to his supplication, O LORD my God, hearkening to the cry and to the prayer which your servant prays before you this day; that your eyes may be open night and day toward this house, the place of which you have said, 'My name shall be there,' that you may hearken to the prayer which your servant offers toward this place. And hearken you to the supplication of your servant and of your people Israel, when they pray toward this place; yes, hear you in heaven your dwelling place; and when you hear, forgive.

"If a man sins against his neighbour and is made to take an oath, and comes and swears his oath before your altar in this house, then hear you in heaven, and act, and judge your servants, condemning the guilty by bringing his conduct upon his own head, and vindicating the righteous by rewarding him according to his righteousness.

"When your people Israel are defeated before the enemy because they have sinned against you, if they turn again to you, and acknowledge your name, and pray and make supplication to you in this house; then hear you in heaven, and forgive the sin of your people Israel, and bring them again to the land which you gave to their fathers.

Now as Solomon finished offering all this prayer and supplication to the LORD, he arose from before the altar of the LORD, where he had knelt with hands outstretched toward heaven; and he stood, and blessed all the assembly of Israel with a loud voice, saying, "Blessed be the LORD who has given rest to his people Israel, according to all that he promised; not one word has failed of all his good promise, which he uttered by Moses his servant.

The LORD our God be with us, as he was with our fathers; may he not leave us or forsake us; that he may incline our hearts to him, to walk in all his ways, and to keep his commandments, his statutes, and his ordinances, which he commanded our fathers. Let these words of mine, wherewith I have made supplication before the LORD, be near to the LORD our God day and night, and may he maintain the cause of his servant, and the cause of his people Israel, as each day requires; that all the peoples of the earth may know that the LORD is God; there is no other. Let your heart therefore be wholly true to the LORD our God, walking in his statutes and keeping his commandments, as at this day."

Responsorial. *Is. 56: 7; 1 Kg. 8: 29*

R: I will lead them to my holy mountain and I will fill them with joy; * because my temple will be called a house of prayer for all the nations.

V: May your eyes be open day and night towards this house, of which you have said: There will my name be!

R: Because my temple will be called a house of prayer for all the nations.

Second Reading. Disc. For Epiphany

Precious is the wisdom with which God is known.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Bernard, abbot.

Wisdom is precious: through it God is known and the world is despised. He who has found it will be blessed if he knows how to keep it. What can be given in order to obtain it? Embrace obedience in your heart,

and you will receive wisdom as a gift. It is written in fact: “If you desire wisdom, observe the commandments; then the Lord will grant it to you” (Sir. 1: 23). If you want to be wise, be obedient. Obedience ignores one’s own will, but submits itself to someone else’s, fulfilling the commands. Embrace it therefore with all the affection of the heart and with all physical strength: embrace, I say, the great good of obedience and through it you will draw near to the light of wisdom. Thus in fact it is written: Draw near to him and you will be illuminated (cfr. Ps. 33: 6 Vulg.). Draw near through obedience, since there is no other access that is more direct and sure, and you will be illuminated by wisdom.

He who does not know God does not know where to go, but walks in darkness and stumbles along the way. Wisdom is that light that illuminates every man who is not wise according to the world, but contrary to this world, so that he will not be of this world though living in it. This is the new man who, putting aside the perverse and contemptible habits of the old man makes efforts to walk in the newness of life, knowing that there is no condemnation for those who do not walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.

As long as you want to follow your will you will not be able to free yourself from the interior turmoil, even if at times you seem to placate the exterior one. This tumult of one’s own will cannot cease in you, until your carnal affection converts and you are thus able to taste God. For this it is affirmed that the wicked are drawn away from the tumult thanks to the light of wisdom, because as soon as they taste how good the Lord is, in that instant they cease to be wicked, adoring finally the Creator and not the creature; and as soon as they detach themselves from their own will, they experience in peace the end of their intimate torment. Having left aside therefore the tumult of the affection and the clamour of the thoughts, peace is made in your heart and here God begins to dwell, since “In peace is his dwelling” (Ps. 75: 3 Vulg.). Where there is God, there is joy; where there is God, there is peace; where there is God, there is happiness.

Responsorial. *Wis. 9: 13, 17, 18; 1 Cor. 2: 14*

R: What man can know the will of God? Who has known your thoughts if you have not granted him your wisdom? * Thus have men been taught what pleases you, and saved, by wisdom.

V: Natural man does not understand the things of the Spirit of God.

R: Thus have men been taught what pleases you, and saved, by wisdom.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 28: 1 – 28*

Wisdom is only with God.

A reading from the book of Job.

"Surely there is a mine for silver, and a place for gold which they refine. Iron is taken out of the earth, and copper is smelted from the ore. Men put an end to darkness, and search out to the farthest bound the ore in gloom and deep darkness.

They open shafts in a valley away from where men live; they are forgotten by travellers, they hang afar from men, they swing to and fro. As for the earth, out of it comes bread; but underneath it is turned up as by fire.

Its stones are the place of sapphires, and it has dust of gold. "That path no bird of prey knows, and the falcon's eye has not seen it. The proud beasts have not trodden it; the lion has not passed over it.

"Man puts his hand to the flinty rock, and overturns mountains by the roots. He cuts out channels in the rocks, and his eye sees every precious thing. He binds up the streams so that they do not trickle, and the thing that is hid he brings forth to light.

"But where shall wisdom be found? And where is the place of understanding? Man does not know the way to it, and it is not found in the land of the living. The deep says, 'It is not in me,' and the sea says, 'It is not with me.'

It cannot be gotten for gold, and silver cannot be weighed as its price. It cannot be valued in the gold of Ophir, in precious onyx or sapphire. Gold and glass cannot equal it, nor can it be exchanged for jewels of fine gold.

No mention shall be made of coral or of crystal; the price of wisdom is above pearls. The topaz of Ethiopia cannot compare with it, nor can it be valued in pure gold. "Whence then comes wisdom? And where is the place of understanding? It is hid from the eyes of all living, and concealed from the birds of the air. Abaddon and Death say, 'We have heard a rumour of it

with our ears.' "God understands the way to it, and he knows its place. For he looks to the ends of the earth, and sees everything under the heavens. When he gave to the wind its weight, and meted out the waters by measure; when he made a decree for the rain, and a way for the lightning of the thunder; then he saw it and declared it; he established it, and searched it out. And he said to man, `Behold, the fear of the Lord, that is wisdom; and to depart from evil is understanding.'"

Responsorial. *1 Cor. 2: 7; 1: 30*

R: We speak of a divine and mysterious wisdom, that has remained hidden,
* preordained by God before the ages for our glory.

V: You are in Christ Jesus: through God he has become wisdom for us,

R: preordained by God before the ages for our glory.

Second Reading. *Book 1, 1:2 – 2: 2, 5:1*

Restless is our heart until we find rest in you.

A reading from the “Confessions” of St. Augustine, bishop.

Great are you, O Lord, and greatly to be praised; great is your power, and of your wisdom there is no end. And man, being a part of your creation, desires to praise you, man, who bears about with him his mortality, the witness of his sin, even the witness that you “resist the proud,” — yet man, this part of your creation, desires to praise you. You move us to delight in praising you; for you have formed us for yourself, and our hearts are restless till they find rest in you?

Lord, teach me to know and understand which of these should be first, to call on you, or to praise you; and likewise to know you, or to call upon you. But who is there that calls upon you without knowing you? For he that knows you not may call upon you as other than you are. Or perhaps we call on you that we may know you. “But how shall they call on Him in whom they have not believed? Or how shall they believe without a preacher?” And those who seek the Lord shall praise Him. For those who seek shall find Him, and those who find Him shall praise Him. Let me seek you, Lord, in calling on you, and call on you in believing in you; for you have been preached unto us. O Lord, my faith calls on you, — that faith which you have imparted to me, which you have breathed into me through the incarnation of your Son, through the ministry of your preacher.

And how shall I call upon my God — my God and my Lord? For when I call on Him I ask Him to come into me. And what place is there in me into which my God can come — into which God can come, even He who made heaven and earth? Is there anything in me, O Lord my God, that can contain you? Do indeed the very heaven and the earth, which you have made, and in which you have made me, contain you? Or, as nothing could exist without you, does whatever exists contain you? Why, then, do I ask you to come into me, since I indeed exist, and could not exist if you were not in me? Because I am not yet in hell, though you are even there; for “if I go down into hell you are there.”

I could not therefore exist, could not exist at all, O my God, unless you were in me. Or should I not rather say, that I could not exist unless I was in you from whom are all things, by whom are all things, in whom are all things? Even so, Lord; even so. Where do I call you to, since you are in me, or whence can you come into me? For where outside heaven and earth can I go that from thence my God may come into me who has said, “I fill heaven and earth”? Oh! How shall I find rest in you? Who will send you into my heart to inebriate it, that I may forget my woes, and embrace you my only good? What are you to me? Have compassion on me, that I may speak. What am I to you that you demand my love, and unless I give it you are angry, and threaten me with great sorrows? Is it, then, a light sorrow not to love you? Alas! Alas! Tell me of your compassion, O Lord my God, what you are to me. “Say unto my soul, I am your salvation.” So speak that I may hear. Behold, Lord, the ears of my heart are before you; you open them, and “say unto my soul, I am your salvation.” When I hear, may I run and lay hold of you. Hide not your face from me. Let me die, lest I die, if only I may see your face.

Responsorial. *Ps. 72: 25-26; 34: 3*

R: I look to no one else in the heaven, I delight in nothing else on earth. My flesh and my heart are pining with love: * my heart’s rock, my own, God forever.

V: Tell my soul: I am your salvation.

R: My heart’s rock, my own, God forever.

YEAR A

Gospel: Mt. 13: 44-52

A Reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up; then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field." Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant in search of fine pearls, who, on finding one pearl of great value, went and sold all that he had and bought it.

"Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a net which was thrown into the sea and gathered fish of every kind; when it was full, men drew it ashore and sat down and sorted the good into vessels but threw away the bad. So it will be at the close of the age. The angels will come out and separate the evil from the righteous, and throw them into the furnace of fire; there men will weep and gnash their teeth. "Have you understood all this?" They said to him, "Yes."

And he said to them, "Therefore every scribe who has been trained for the kingdom of heaven is like a householder who brings out of his treasure what is new and what is old."

Third Reading. Book 10: 9-10

The splendid pearl leads to the unique precious pearl.

A reading from the "Homilies of Matthew" of Origen, presbyter.

To the one who searches for the precious pearl can be applied that word: "Search and you will find...He who searches finds" (Lk. 11: 9, 10). But what should he search for? Or better, what does it mean: he who searches finds? Undoubtedly he is referring to that pearl which one day he who despises all his goods and sells them will possess; for this Paul says: "I look on everything as so much rubbish if only I can have Christ" (Phil 3: 8) who is the only precious pearl.

For those who are in the dark the lamp is precious and they use it until the rising of the sun; the glory that appears on the face of Moses and on that of the other prophets is also precious; through it we can deduce that we too will arrive to the contemplation of the glory of Christ, to whom the Father gave witness saying: "This is my beloved Son in whom I am well pleased" (Mt. 3: 17).

But that which then was manifested in part has not been glorified, because of a greater glory; even if to us that glory, which later would have been abolished, was necessary in order to prepare us for that glory which was definite and perfect.

For example the imperfect science, which will then have its end when the perfect one will arrive, is necessary.

Every soul, in fact, that finds itself in the first age and aspires to perfection, needs a pedagogue, of administrators and legal representatives, until it reaches a mature age.

Then, he who was not at all different from a servant even though he was the master of all, having become finally free, receives the paternal goods from the pedagogue, from the administrators and from the legal representatives.

All of which, having made the due proportions, corresponds to the precious pearl and to the perfection that cancels with its coming that which is imperfect and partial, when that is someone reaches the perfection of the doctrine of Christ, after having been prepared by all that knowledge which is in a certain way ordered towards the full knowledge of the Lord.

Many however, not perceiving the beauty of the uncountable pearls of the law and the validity of the doctrine of the prophets, although still incomplete, delude themselves by thinking that they will be able to find the precious pearl and reach, without the help of those explanations and ideas, the contemplation of the extraordinary beauty of the knowledge of Christ Jesus.

In comparison to this, it can be said that all that which has preceded a similar marvellous knowledge, even if it cannot be called exactly dung, yet it seems to be such.

However, it is exactly the dung that the vinedresser puts around the fig tree that helps the plant to produce fruit.

For every thing therefore there is the opportune time and every reality that lives under the heaven has its favourable occasion. There is therefore a time to gather splendid pearls and, after having gathered them, there is a time to find the unique precious pearl, when it is necessary to go and to sell everything that you possess in order to buy it.

Responsorial. *Phil. 3: 7, 10, 8*

R: But because of Christ, I have come to consider all these advantages that I had as disadvantages. * All I want is to know Christ and the power of his resurrection and to share his sufferings by reproducing the pattern of his death.

V: For him I have accepted the loss of everything, and I look on everything as so much rubbish if only I can have Christ.

R: All I want is to know Christ and the power of his resurrection and to share his sufferings by reproducing the pattern of his death.

YEAR B

Gospel. *Jn. 6: 1-15*

A reading from the Gospel of St. John.

After this Jesus went to the other side of the Sea of Galilee, which is the Sea of Tiber'i-as. And a multitude followed him, because they saw the signs that he did on those who were diseased. Jesus went up on the mountain, and there sat down with his disciples.

Now the Passover, the feast of the Jews, was at hand. Lifting up his eyes, then, and seeing that a multitude was coming to him, Jesus said to Philip, "How are we to buy bread, so that these people may eat?" This he said to test him, for he himself knew what he would do. Philip answered him, "Two hundred denarii would not buy enough bread for each of them to get a little." One of his disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter's brother, said to him, "There is a lad here who has five barley loaves and two fish; but what are they among so many?"

Jesus said, "Make the people sit down." Now there was much grass in the place; so the men sat down, in number about five thousand. Jesus then took the loaves, and when he had given thanks, he distributed them to those who were seated; so also the fish, as much as they wanted. And when they had eaten their fill, he told his disciples, "Gather up the fragments left over, that nothing may be lost." So they gathered them up and filled twelve baskets with fragments from the five barley loaves, left by those who had eaten.

When the people saw the sign that he had done, they said, "This is indeed the prophet who is to come into the world!" Perceiving then that

they were about to come and take him by force to make him king, Jesus withdrew again to the mountain by himself.

Third Reading. *P. II. C. 3*

We are invited to faith, which is the work of God.

A reading from the work “The sacrament of the altar” of Baldwin of Canterbury, bishop.

“This is the work of God: to believe in him whom he has sent” (Jn. 6: 29). The crowd questioned Jesus on the works that he had to accomplish, as if they were many: he instead answers as if he was dealing with only one. Faith, which works through love, in fact is the true work of God, and it is the beginning, that we have in ourselves, of all our good actions. “In fact without faith it is impossible to be pleasing (Heb. 11: 6). The Jews asked what was the works of God because they did not as yet have faith, without which they could not fulfil the works of God: for this they were invited to faith which is the work of God, that is to believe in him whom God had sent. Since they understood that he was referring to himself, they asked him: “What sign therefore will you do so that we can see and believe in you? What work will you accomplish?” (Jn. 6: 30).

Behold the Jews ask for signs: the miracle of the multiplication of the five loaves of bread is not enough for them; it is a short time in fact that he has distributed the bread of wheat, in order to believe that Christ is so powerful as to give a food that lasts for eternal life. Not even Moses, who obtained for them the manna from heaven, made such promises. They compare therefore the miracle of Moses as something that is much greater than the multiplication of bread, almost as if that which Christ had said about himself was not worthy of faith. And thus they added: “Our fathers have eaten the manna in the desert, as it is written: He gave them a bread from heaven to eat” (Jn. 6: 31)

Christ answers to what they were saying with regard to the bread given from heaven to their fathers, showing that the true bread of heaven had not been given through Moses, but that now the Father was giving it. In fact he says to them: “Truly, truly I say to you, it was not Moses who gave you bread from heaven, but my Father who gives you bread from heaven” (Jn. 6: 32). But they, understanding this in the material sense, say to him: “Lord, give us that bread always” (Jn. 6: 34). Like the Samaritan woman who on

hearing him say: “He who drinks of the water that I shall give will not be thirsty again” (Jn. 4: 14), immediately imagined that he was speaking of the physical thirst, and desiring not to have that need any more said: “Lord, give me this water, so that I may never get thirsty and never have to come here again to draw water” (Jn. 4: 15), so also the Jews answered: “Lord, give us always this bread” (Jn. 6: 24), naturally so that he may satisfy us and we will never be lacking. Therefore, after the miracle of the five loaves of bread, they wanted to make him king. But Jesus brings them back to his person, and reveals more clearly of what bread he had spoken, saying: “I am the bread of life: he who comes to me will never hunger again and he who believes in me will never be thirsty again” (Jn. 6: 35).

He who comes to me: as before he had affirmed “He who believes in me”. And it is necessary to understand what he wanted to say with these words: “will not hunger again and will not thirst again”. The sense of the two things is in fact the eternal satiety, where nothing will be lacking.

Responsorial. *Heb. 11: 6; Is. 7: 9*

R: Without faith it is impossible to be pleasing to God: * Since anyone who comes to him must believe that he exists and rewards those who try to find him.

V: If you do not believe, you will not have stability.

R: Since anyone who comes to him must believe that he exists and rewards those who try to find him.

YEAR C

Gospel. *Lk. 11: 1- 13*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Luke.

He was praying in a certain place, and when he ceased, one of his disciples said to him, "Lord, teach us to pray, as John taught his disciples." And he said to them, "When you pray, say: "Father, hallowed be your name. Your kingdom come. Give us each day our daily bread; and forgive us our sins, for we ourselves forgive every one who is indebted to us; and lead us not into temptation."

And he said to them, "Which of you who has a friend will go to him at midnight and say to him, 'Friend, lend me three loaves; for a friend of mine has arrived on a journey, and I have nothing to set before him'; and he will

answer from within, 'Do not bother me; the door is now shut, and my children are with me in bed; I cannot get up and give you anything'? I tell you, though he will not get up and give him anything because he is his friend, yet because of his importunity he will rise and give him whatever he needs.

And I tell you, Ask, and it will be given you; seek, and you will find; knock and it will be opened to you. For every one who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened.

What father among you, if his son asks for a fish, will instead of a fish give him a serpent; or if he asks for an egg, will give him a scorpion? If you then, who are evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will the heavenly Father give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him!"

Third Reading. Hom 14

These are the gifts that we should ask for.

A reading from the "Homilies" of St. Bede the venerable, presbyter.

The Lord is our Saviour, who desiring that we reach the happiness of the heavenly kingdom, teaches us to ask him for those joys, and he has promised us that he would have given it to us if we had asked him for it. "Ask – he says – and it will be given to you, search and you will find, knock and it will be opened to you" (Lk. 11: 9). These words of the Lord, dearest brothers, must be meditated upon deeply and with the maximum attention by us, since they affirm that the kingdom of heaven will not be for the idle and the loafers, but it will be given, found and opened to those who ask, who search and who knock.

We must therefore ask in prayer that the door of the kingdom be opened to us, search for it with an upright life and knock on it with perseverance. But it is not enough to pray only with words, if we do not also search with a lot of diligence in what manner we should live in order to be worthy of obtaining that for which we ask, according to the affirmation of him who said: "It is not those who say to me: Lord, Lord, who will enter into the kingdom of heaven, but he who does the will of my Father who is in heaven" (Mt. 7: 21).

Therefore it is necessary, my brothers, to ask assiduously, to ask without interruption: "Prostrating ourselves let us kneel in front of the Lord who made us" (Ps. 94: 6). And in order to be worthy to be heard, let us

reflect diligently on how he who has created us desires that we live and what he has commanded us to do. Let us search for the Lord and be confident, let us search always for his face. And in order to be worthy to find him and to see him, “Let us purify ourselves from every stain of the flesh and of the spirit” (2 Cor. 7: 1), because on the day of the resurrection only those who have kept the chastity of the body will go up to heaven and only the pure of heart will be able to contemplate the glory of the divine majesty.

If then we wish to know what he wants us to ask, let us listen to the evangelical text: “Search first for the kingdom of God and his justice, and all these things will be given to you as well” (Mt. 6: 33). To search for the kingdom of God and its justice means to desire the gifts of the heavenly homeland and to inquire unceasingly with which holy acts it is possible to succeed in possessing it, so that it may not happen that deviating from the right way we may be unable to reach the place to which we are aiming.

These above all, dearest brothers, are the goods for which we must ask for from God; we must search for this justice of the kingdom of God before all the other things, that is faith, hope and charity, as it is written: “The just man will live in virtue of faith” (Gal. 3: 11); “grace surrounds the one who trusts in the Lord” (Ps. 31: 10) and “complete fulfilment of the law is love” (Rm. 13: 10).

“The entire law in fact finds its fullness in only one precept: you will love your neighbour as yourself” (Gal. 5: 14).

For this the Lord, with loving promise, assures: “Your heavenly Father will give the Holy Spirit to those who ask him” (Lk. 11: 13), in order to demonstrate how those who by nature are wicked can become good by welcoming the grace of the Holy Spirit. He promises that the Father will give the good Spirit to those who ask him, because the faith, hope and charity, like all the other heavenly goods that we desire to obtain, are lavished uniquely by the grace of the Spirit.

Letting ourselves be guided by his inspirations according to our capacity, dearest brothers, we ask God the Father to lead us in the virtue of his Spirit, along the way of the right faith, that works through love. And in order to obtain the desired goods, let us make efforts to live in a manner that is not unworthy of such a Father; on the contrary let us keep, always intact, with a virgin body and pure mind, the mystery of the regeneration, through which in baptism we have become children of God.

It is certain in fact that if we observe the commandments of the Father, he will reward us with the inheritance of an eternal blessing, prepared for us from the beginning of the ages in Jesus Christ our Lord, who lives and reigns, God, in the unity of the Holy Spirit, forever and ever. Amen.

Responsorial. *Jer. 29: 12-13; Lk. 11: 9*

R: You will invoke me and you will appeal to me and I will hear you; you will search for me and you will find me * because you search for me with all your heart.

V: Ask and it will be given to you, search and you will find;

R: because you search for me with all your heart.

MONDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 10: 1 – 13*

The glory of Solomon in front of the Queen of Sheba.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Now when the queen of Sheba heard of the fame of Solomon concerning the name of the LORD, she came to test him with hard questions. She came to Jerusalem with a very great retinue, with camels bearing spices, and very much gold, and precious stones; and when she came to Solomon, she told him all that was on her mind. And Solomon answered all her questions; there was nothing hidden from the king that he could not explain to her. And when the queen of Sheba had seen all the wisdom of Solomon, the house that he had built, the food of his table, the seating of his officials, and the attendance of his servants, their clothing, his cupbearers, and his burnt offerings which he offered at the house of the LORD, there was no more spirit in her. And she said to the king, "The report was true which I heard in my own land of your affairs and of your wisdom, but I did not believe the reports until I came and my own eyes had seen it; and, behold, the half was not told me; your wisdom and prosperity surpass the report which I heard. Happy are your wives! Happy are these your servants, who continually stand before you and hear your wisdom! Blessed be the LORD your God, who has delighted in you and set you on the throne of Israel! Because the LORD loved Israel for ever, he has made you king, that you may execute justice and righteousness."

Then she gave the king a hundred and twenty talents of gold, and a very great quantity of spices, and precious stones; never again came such an abundance of spices as these which the queen of Sheba gave to King Solomon. Moreover the fleet of Hiram, which brought gold from Ophir, brought from Ophir a very great amount of sandalwood and precious stones. And the king made of the sandal wood supports for the house of the LORD, and for the king's house, lyres also and harps for the singers; no such sandalwood has come or been seen, to this day. And King Solomon gave to the queen of Sheba all that she desired, whatever she asked besides what

was given her by the bounty of King Solomon. So she turned and went back to her own land, with her servants.

Responsorial. *Lk. 11: 31; 1 Kg. 10: 4, 5*

R: The queen of the south will rise up in judgement together with the men of this generation and will condemn it, because she came from the ends of the earth to hear the wisdom of Solomon. * And behold, there is something greater than Solomon here.

V: The queen of Sheba, when she had admired all the wisdom of Solomon remained breathless.

R: And behold, there is something greater than Solomon here.

Second Reading. *Disc. 53*

Christ is wisdom.

A reading from the “Discourses” of Peter of Blois, presbyter.

Many have searched for wisdom and not found it; many have found it but did not know how to keep it. Blessed instead is he who places his dwelling in wisdom (cfr. Sir. 14: 24-25). Solomon found wisdom but did not dwell in it because led astray by foreign woman he became foolish. Highest wisdom is that which the world considers foolishness, that is the wisdom of Christ; in fact, the wisdom which is Christ himself: “who” as the Apostle says, “by the work of God has become for us” not only “wisdom”, but also “justice, sanctification and redemption” (1 Cor. 1: 30). Therefore Paul, educated in the school of this wisdom, says: “the only knowledge that I claimed to have was Jesus and only about him as the crucified Christ” (1 Cor. 2: 2).

It is truly a good thing to search for and to keep this wisdom which is sanctification and redemption. From the moment that every other wisdom is vanity and the source of perdition, you cannot be anything else but a disciple of this school: “Whoever among you who does not renounce to all his goods, cannot be my disciple” (Lk. 14: 33); and again: “He who does not hate his father, his mother and his own life too cannot be my disciple” (Lk. 14: 26). O good Jesus! Why have you done this to us? Moses had placed a weight on our shoulders that neither our fathers nor we were able to carry. We hoped that you, seeing, would have lightened our burdens; instead your hand is heavier upon us. Were not the hands of Moses heavy

enough? Have you come to kill us with your rod? Are you searching for material in order to stir up your anger against us and make us perish? Are you not Jesus, the Saviour, who has come to save us and not to lead us to ruin? Why do you command that which I am not able to fulfil? To hate my father and my mother and my own life; and to love instead my enemies? “This language is hard; who can understand it?” (Jn. 6: 60). I would like to turn my steps to other schools, and to choose another master; but I hear Peter answering for himself and in the name of the other apostles: “Lord, to whom shall we go? You have the words of eternal life” (Jn. 6: 68). If your command appears burdensome and your language hard, yet I know that “great is your goodness, Lord, and you reserve it for those who fear you” (Ps. 30: 20). For this I will hope always in you, your wisdom cannot fail, your power cannot be overcome, your benevolence does not know tiredness, your charity cannot diminish. Even if you want to scourge me, to burn me, to beat me, to kill me, I will continue to hope in you, Lord: only help me, and teach me to do your will; show me, Lord, a sign of your benevolence because I search for you and I hope in you. You in fact are good with those who hope in you, with the soul that searches for you. I know with certainty that all those who serve you are not oppressed, but on the contrary honoured, because “you have made your friends great, Lord” (Ps. 138: 17 Vulg.). I know that any type of yoke of slavery will become acceptable in the remembrance of your sweetness.

Responsorial. *Wis. 15: 3; Jn. 17: 3*

R: To know you is perfect justice, * to know your power is the root of immortality.

V: This is eternal life: that they know you, the one true God, and he whom you have sent; Jesus Christ.

R: To know your power is the root of immortality.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 29:1 – 10; 30: 1, 9 – 23*

Job laments about his own condition.

A reading from the book of Job.

And Job again took up his discourse, and said: "Oh, that I were as in the months of old, as in the days when God watched over me; when his lamp shone upon my head, and by his light I walked through darkness; as I was in my autumn days, when the friendship of God was upon my tent; when the Almighty was yet with me, when my children were about me; when my steps were washed with milk, and the rock poured out for me streams of oil!

When I went out to the gate of the city, when I prepared my seat in the square, the young men saw me and withdrew, and the aged rose and stood; the princes refrained from talking, and laid their hand on their mouth; the voice of the nobles was hushed, and their tongue cleaved to the roof of their mouth. "But now they make sport of me, men who are younger than I, whose fathers I would have disdained to set with the dogs of my flock.

"And now I have become their song, I am a byword to them. They abhor me, they keep aloof from me; they do not hesitate to spit at the sight of me. Because God has loosed my cord and humbled me, they have cast off restraint in my presence. On my right hand the rabble rise, they drive me forth, they cast up against me their ways of destruction.

They break up my path, they promote my calamity; no one restrains them. As through a wide breach they come; amid the crash they roll on. Terrors are turned upon me; my honour is pursued as by the wind, and my prosperity has passed away like a cloud.

"And now my soul is poured out within me; days of affliction have taken hold of me. The night racks my bones, and the pain that gnaws me takes no rest. With violence it seizes my garment; it binds me about like the collar of my tunic. God has cast me into the mire, and I have become like dust and ashes. I cry to you and you do not answer me; I stand, and you do not heed me. You have turned cruel to me; with the might of your hand you persecute me. You lift me up on the wind, you make me ride on it, and you toss me about in the roar of the storm. Yes, I know that you will bring me to death, and to the house appointed for all living.

Responsorial. *Jb. 30: 17, 19; 7: 16*

R: At night sickness saps my bones, I am gnawed by wounds that never sleep. It has thrown me into the mud: * where I am no better than dust and ashes.

V: Leave me Lord, for my days are but a breath;
R: where I am no better than dust and ashes.

Second Reading. Disc. 7

The reason of every disturbance is that no one accuses himself.

A reading from the “Spiritual discourses” of St. Dorotheus, abbot.

Let us see, my brothers, why it is that sometimes when a person hears words that hurt him he can let them pass by without any bother as if he had not heard them, whilst at other times, as soon as he hears them he is troubled and upset. My question is – what is the cause of this difference? Is there one reason for this or are there many? I think there are several, but there is one in particular which is the source of all the others, as the saying goes: it results from the state of mind the person is in at that particular time.

For example, when someone is caught as he comes from prayer or contemplation, he is then in the best of dispositions and is able to put up with his brother and remain undisturbed. It may be that he has great affection for the other and so, out of love, puts up patiently with everything. But it can also happen that he despises the one who wants to upset him, regarding him as the lowest of men and not worth even a reply. Nor would he even consider mentioning his slights and insults to someone else.

Hence, as I said, it can be that a man is not disturbed or upset because he has only contempt for the things that are said to him and ignores them. The brother who insults us may upset us either because we are not at the moment in the right mood or because we dislike him intensely. There are many other reasons as well which are described in different ways. But, if we examine the matter closely, we can say that the reason for all disturbance is that no one blames himself.

This is the reason for every taking of offence and upset. This is why at times it is impossible to find peace of soul. Nor should we be surprised at this, since it is the teaching of spiritual men that there is no other way of peace for us. This we can see to be true in so many people. And yet we hope for peace but do not follow their teaching. Or, we believe that we are on the right path while we are irritated by everything and cannot bear to take any blame upon ourselves.

That is the way things are. A man may indeed accomplish innumerable good deeds, but if he does not master this he will never attain peace.

Instead, he will always oppress himself and oppress others and his labours will go for nothing.

Responsorial. *1 Jn. 1: 8. 9; Pr. 28: 13*

R: If we say we have no sin in us, we are deceiving ourselves, * but if we acknowledge our sins, then God who is faithful and just will forgive our sins.

V: He who conceals his faults will not prosper,

R: but if we acknowledge our sins, then God who is faithful and just will forgive our sins.

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 31 – 35*

*The mustard seed becomes a tree,
so much so that the birds of heaven make their nests among its branches.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Another parable he put before them, saying, "The kingdom of heaven is like a grain of mustard seed which a man took and sowed in his field; it is the smallest of all seeds, but when it has grown it is the greatest of shrubs and becomes a tree, so that the birds of the air come and make nests in its branches."

He told them another parable. "The kingdom of heaven is like leaven which a woman took and hid in three measures of flour, till it was all leavened."

All this Jesus said to the crowds in parables; indeed he said nothing to them without a parable. This was to fulfil what was spoken by the prophet: "I will open my mouth in parables, I will utter what has been hidden since the foundation of the world."

TUESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 11: 1 – 4, 26 – 43*

The faults of Solomon. Rebellion and flight of Jeroboam.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Now King Solomon loved many foreign women: the daughter of Pharaoh, and Moabite, Ammonite, E'domite, Sido'nian, and Hittite women, from the nations concerning which the LORD had said to the people of Israel, "You shall not enter into marriage with them, neither shall they with you, for surely they will turn away your heart after their gods"; Solomon clung to these in love. He had seven hundred wives, princesses, and three hundred concubines; and his wives turned away his heart. For when Solomon was old his wives turned away his heart after other gods; and his heart was not wholly true to the LORD his God, as was the heart of David his father.

Jerobo'am the son of Nebat, an E'phraimite of Zer'edah, a servant of Solomon, whose mother's name was Zeru'ah, a widow, also lifted up his hand against the king. And this was the reason why he lifted up his hand against the king. Solomon built the Millo, and closed up the breach of the city of David his father. The man Jerobo'am was very able, and when Solomon saw that the young man was industrious he gave him charge over all the forced labour of the house of Joseph. And at that time, when Jerobo'am went out of Jerusalem, the prophet Ahi'jah the Shi'lonite found him on the road. Now Ahi'jah had clad himself with a new garment; and the two of them were alone in the open country. Then Ahi'jah laid hold of the new garment that was on him, and tore it into twelve pieces. And he said to Jerobo'am, "Take for yourself ten pieces; for thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, `Behold, I am about to tear the kingdom from the hand of Solomon, and will give you ten tribes but he shall have one tribe, for the sake of my servant David and for the sake of Jerusalem, the city which I have chosen out of all the tribes of Israel, because he has forsaken me, and worshiped Ash'toreth the goddess of the Sido'nians, Chemosh the god of Moab, and Milcom the god of the Ammonites, and has not walked in my ways, doing what is right in my sight and keeping my statutes and my

ordinances, as David his father did. Nevertheless I will not take the whole kingdom out of his hand; but I will make him ruler all the days of his life, for the sake of David my servant whom I chose, who kept my commandments and my statutes; but I will take the kingdom out of his son's hand, and will give it to you, ten tribes. Yet to his son I will give one tribe, that David my servant may always have a lamp before me in Jerusalem, the city where I have chosen to put my name. And I will take you, and you shall reign over all that your soul desires, and you shall be king over Israel. And if you will hearken to all that I command you, and will walk in my ways, and do what is right in my eyes by keeping my statutes and my commandments, as David my servant did, I will be with you, and will build you a sure house, as I built for David, and I will give Israel to you. And I will for this afflict the descendants of David, but not for ever."

Solomon sought therefore to kill Jerobo'am; but Jerobo'am arose, and fled into Egypt, to Shishak king of Egypt, and was in Egypt until the death of Solomon.

Now the rest of the acts of Solomon, and all that he did, and his wisdom, are they not written in the book of the acts of Solomon? And the time that Solomon reigned in Jerusalem over all Israel was forty years.

And Solomon slept with his fathers, and was buried in the city of David his father; and Rehobo'am his son reigned in his stead.

Responsorial. *Sir. 47: 20, 22; 2 Tm. 2: 13*

R: Solomon, stained your glory: but the Lord will not go back on his mercy,
* and he will not go back on any of his words.

V: God remains faithful, because he cannot disown his own self.

R: And he will not go back on any of his words.

Second Reading. *Disc. 167*

Do penance, because the kingdom of heaven is near.

A reading from the "Discourses" of St. Peter Chrysologus, bishop.

Do penance: why not, rather, enjoy? Yes, rejoice, because the divine reality follows the human one, to the earthly the heavenly one, to the temporal the eternal, to the wicked the good, to the uncertain the certain, to distress peace, to the fallen realities the eternal ones. "You must repent" (Act. 2: 38). Let him truly repent, let him repent, who places the human

before the divine, who prefers to serve the world, rather than to dominate it together with the Lord of the world. Let him who prefers to perish with the evil one rather than reign with Christ, do penance. Let him who despising the liberty of virtue, wants to be a prisoner of vices, do penance. Let him who abandoning life, hands himself to death, do penance, and not a little.

Near in fact is the kingdom of heaven (cfr. Mt. 4: 17). The kingdom of heaven is the reward for the just, judgement for the sinners, punishment for the wicked. Blessed therefore John, who in penance wanted for himself the judgement while for the wicked he wanted to obtain the reward of entering into the kingdom, not the punishment. John proclaimed then near at hand the kingdom of heaven, when the world still a child grew in age.

At the present we know that the kingdom is even closer, since the world, weakened by the extreme old age, prostrated without strength, devoid of its senses and, oppressed by pains, refuses every care: it dies to life in order to live of sickness, accuse its weakness, affirming in this way the end which is already near.

But harder than the Jews, we follow the world that flees, we do not think about the future time and we anchor ourselves to the present; we already fear the judgement, yet we do not take a step towards the Lord who already comes; we prefer death, rather than the resurrection from the dead; we, who want to serve, and we refuse to reign, to the point of postponing as far as possible the kingdom of our Lord. How can we realise therefore that word: "When you pray say: Your kingdom come"? (Lk. 11: 2).

We have need of greater penance, adapting the medicine to our wounds. Let us do penance, brothers, let us do it soon since the time flees from us, already our hour moves to its end, and the judgement already present takes away from us the possibility of satisfying our debt. Let our penance be diligent, in order not to be preceded by the sentence: if the Lord still does not come, still waits, still delays, it is because he desires that we return to him and that we do not perish, as the word that in his great mercy he always addresses to us, gives witness: "I do not take pleasure in the death of the wicked, but that he desists from his conduct and lives" (Ez. 33: 11).

Let us convert therefore brothers, and let us not despair because of the limited time, because the author of time does not know limits: this finds a confirmation in the thief of the gospel who on the cross and on the point of death abducted forgiveness, seized life, forced open paradise and broke into

the kingdom. And we, brothers, who did not know how to merit it with the will, let us at least do virtue because of necessity: and so as not to be judged, let us judge ourselves of the penance that we must do in order to keep away from us the condemnation.

Responsorial. *Sir. 18: 30; 1 Pet. 2: 11*

R: Do not follow the passions, * restrain your desires.

V: The desires of the flesh make war on the soul:

R: Restrain your desires.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Jb. 31: 1 – 8, 13 – 23, 35 – 37*

Job has always acted according to justice.

A reading from the book of Job.

"I have made a covenant with my eyes; how then could I look upon a virgin? What would be my portion from God above, and my heritage from the Almighty on high? Does not calamity befall the unrighteous, and disaster the workers of iniquity? Does not he see my ways, and number all my steps?

"If I have walked with falsehood, and my foot has hastened to deceit; let me be weighed in a just balance, and let God know my integrity! If my step has turned aside from the way, and my heart has gone after my eyes, and if any spot has cleaved to my hands; then let me sow, and another eat; and let what grows for me be rooted out. "If I have rejected the cause of my manservant or my maidservant, when they brought a complaint against me; what then shall I do when God rises up? When he makes inquiry, what shall I answer him?

Did not he who made me in the womb make him? And did not one fashion us in the womb? "If I have withheld anything that the poor desired, or have caused the eyes of the widow to fail, or have eaten my morsel alone, and the fatherless has not eaten of it for from his youth I reared him as a father, and from his mother's womb I guided him.

If I have seen any one perish for lack of clothing, or a poor man without covering; if his loins have not blessed me, and if he was not

warmed with the fleece of my sheep; if I have raised my hand against the fatherless, because I saw help in the gate; then let my shoulder blade fall from my shoulder, and let my arm be broken from its socket. For I was in terror of calamity from God, and I could not have faced his majesty. Oh, that I had one to hear me! (Here is my signature! let the Almighty answer me!) Oh, that I had the indictment written by my adversary! Surely I would carry it on my shoulder; I would bind it on me as a crown; I would give him an account of all my steps; like a prince I would approach him.

Responsorial. *Jb. 31: 3, 4; Pr. 15: 3*

R: For the wicked is reserved ruin and calamities for the iniquitous. * The eyes of the Lord scrutinise the wicked and the good in every place.

V: Does he not see my conduct and does he not count all my steps?

R: The eyes of the Lord scrutinise the wicked and the good in every place.

Second Reading. *Disc. 13*

The false peace of the spirit.

A reading from the “Spiritual discourses” of St. Dorotheus, abbot.

Whenever some sort of inconvenience or penalty or dishonour or trouble of any kind happens to one who is ready to find fault with himself, he bears it with a smile, considers that he deserves it and so is not in the least put out by it. Who could be more peaceful than such a person?

Perhaps someone will object, ‘But what if a brother should vex me and after examining myself I find that I have given him no cause, how then can I blame myself?’

But surely if a person were to examine himself carefully in the light of the fear of God he will never find that he is blameless. He will see that he has provided an occasion by some action or word or attitude. Even if such a one finds himself guiltless in all these ways at the present time, it is quite likely that at some other time he has vexed his brother by the very same deed or by some other. Or he may have upset another brother. Hence he deservedly suffers for that sin or for many other sins that he has committed elsewhere.

Another may ask why he should accuse himself when he has been sitting in peace and quiet and a brother has come up and upset him with

some hurtful or insulting word. Since he is not going to put up with that, he feels that it is reasonable for him to be annoyed and upset. For, if the other had not intruded and spoken and made trouble he would not have sinned.

This indeed is ridiculous and it is bad logic. Surely that brother did not inject the passion of anger into him by saying what he did? Rather he revealed the passion already within him, so that if he so wishes he may repent of it. This brother is like early wheat, outwardly bright and shining and when it is crushed it's rottenness appears.

So this man who sits in peace and quiet, as he thinks, has within him a passion he does not see. One hurtful word spoken by another who happens by and immediately all the poison and rottenness within gushes out. If he wishes to gain mercy let him repent and purify himself and make serious efforts to do better and he will see that instead of insults he should give thanks to that brother as one responsible for bringing him such a benefit. Temptations will not trouble him so much in the future because the more he progresses the easier he will be able to handle them. For as the soul advances it becomes stronger and better able to put up with whatever hardships may come its way.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jb. 9: 2, 14; 15: 15*

R: Indeed I know that no man can be in the right against God. * How dare I plead my cause, then, or choose arguments against him?

V: In his own Holy Ones God puts no trust, and the heavens themselves are not clean in his eyes.

R: How dare I plead my cause, then, or choose arguments against him?

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 36 – 43*

As the weed is collected and is burnt in the fire, so also will happen at the end of the world.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

Then he left the crowds and went into the house. And his disciples came to him, saying, "Explain to us the parable of the weeds of the field." He answered, "He who sows the good seed is the Son of man; the field is the world, and the good seed means the sons of the kingdom; the weeds are the sons of the evil one, and the enemy who sowed them is the devil; the harvest is the close of the age, and the reapers are angels. Just as the weeds

are gathered and burned with fire, so will it be at the close of the age. The Son of man will send his angels, and they will gather out of his kingdom all causes of sin and all evildoers, and throw them into the furnace of fire; there men will weep and gnash their teeth. Then the righteous will shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father. He who has ears, let him hear.

WEDNESDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 12:1 – 19*

Division of the kingdom at the time of Rehoboam son of Solomon.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

Rehobo'am went to Shechem, for all Israel had come to Shechem to make him king. And when Jerobo'am the son of Nebat heard of it (for he was still in Egypt, whither he had fled from King Solomon), then Jerobo'am returned from Egypt. And they sent and called him; and Jerobo'am and all the assembly of Israel came and said to Rehobo'am, "Your father made our yoke heavy. Now therefore lighten the hard service of your father and his heavy yoke upon us, and we will serve you." He said to them, "Depart for three days, then come again to me." So the people went away. Then King Rehobo'am took counsel with the old men, who had stood before Solomon his father while he was yet alive, saying, "How do you advise me to answer this people?" And they said to him, "If you will be a servant to this people today and serve them, and speak good words to them when you answer them, then they will be your servants for ever." But he forsook the counsel that the old men gave him, and took counsel with the young men who had grown up with him and stood before him. And he said to them, "What do you advise that we answer this people who have said to me, 'Lighten the yoke that your father put upon us'?" And the young men who had grown up with him said to him, "Thus shall you speak to this people who said to you, 'Your father made our yoke heavy, but do you lighten it for us'; thus shall you say to them, 'My little finger is thicker than my father's loins. And now, whereas my father laid upon you a heavy yoke, I will add to your yoke. My father chastised you with whips, but I will chastise you with scorpions.'"

So Jerobo'am and all the people came to Rehobo'am the third day, as the king said, "Come to me again the third day." And the king answered the people harshly, and forsaking the counsel which the old men had given him, he spoke to them according to the counsel of the young men, saying, "My father made your yoke heavy, but I will add to your yoke; my father chastised you with whips, but I will chastise you with scorpions." So the king did not hearken to the people; for it was a turn of affairs brought about

by the LORD that he might fulfil his word, which the LORD spoke by Ahi'jah the Shi'lonite to Jerobo'am the son of Nebat. And when all Israel saw that the king did not hearken to them, the people answered the king, "What portion have we in David? We have no inheritance in the son of Jesse. To your tents, O Israel! Look now to your own house, David." So Israel departed to their tents. But Rehobo'am reigned over the people of Israel who dwelt in the cities of Judah.

Then King Rehobo'am sent Ador'am, who was taskmaster over the forced labour, and all Israel stoned him to death with stones. And King Rehobo'am made haste to mount his chariot, to flee to Jerusalem. So Israel has been in rebellion against the house of David to this day.

Responsorial. *2 Kg. 17: 21, 22, 23; cfr. Ez. 37: 22, 25*

R: Jeroboam had drawn Israel away from following the Lord, and the Israelites imitated all the sins committed by Jeroboam, until at length the Lord thrust Israel away from him, * as he had foretold through the prophets.

V: They will no longer form two nations, nor will they be divided in two separate kingdoms, they will live in their land forever.

R: As he has foretold through the prophets.

Second Reading. *Book 5, t. 1, 53,12*

Christ has died for us.

A reading from the “Commentary on the prophet Isaiah” of St. Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

It is written that God has made out of the two nations one new man (cfr. Ep. 2: 15); and I think that in this way God the Father wants to give justice to the Just One, who serves well the multitude remitting their sins himself. The Just One then who serves well the multitude, cannot be understood as any other than our Lord Jesus Christ, who, according to the economy of the incarnation, did not come to be served, as he himself says, but to serve. For this St. Paul called him minister. He says in fact, when speaking of the Law and of the New Testament: “If there was any splendour in administering condemnation, there must be very much greater splendour in administering justification.” (2 Cor. 3: 9).

It is therefore the Christ, just and irreproachable, who serves the multitude well. The Word of God in fact assumed the form of a servant, not in order to assist his own nature, but to give us his help, in order that is to fulfil for us that ministry thanks to which we have been saved. He then was justified when the suspicion that he was wicked and worthy of suffering the death on the cross was cancelled. In fact while the Israelites satisfied in him the punishment that was due to them for their wickedness, he reigned over all the earth and over all the nations that hastened to him. That the economy of the incarnation carries out a ministry that is so efficacious is demonstrated in the Scriptures when it says that he will forgive their sins.

In fact, in order to take away the sins of the world, he took the sins on himself and died for all, he who was superior to all: in this way he served the multitude. When he says ‘many’, understand the nations; Israel in fact was only one people. And since he carried their sins, he says: “Hence I will grant whole hordes for his tribute, he shall divide the spoil with the mighty” (Is. 53: 12 Vulg.). In the ‘many’ recognise those who come from the nations: these in fact were more numerous than the Israelites; for ‘powerful’ understand the holy apostles, or also simply all those who are powerful in Christ and gifted with a spiritual strength: among them, who have overcome Satan, he distributes the booty.

He divides with abundance the reserve of the spiritual gifts among his saints; it is written in fact: To one is granted by the Holy Spirit the language of wisdom, to another the language of science, to another the gift of prophecy, to another the gift of distinguishing the spirits, to another the gift of healing (cfr. 1 Cor. 12: 8-10). Let us attribute to the holy apostles the power of language, and let us affirm that all the nations were like a possession of Satan. But he who possesses everything, divided them among his holy doctors. Some in fact were called to the knowledge of Christ our Saviour by the holy apostle Peter; others were led to the light of the truth by the teaching of Paul, or of one of the other apostles. Almost like booty or the plunder of war, the Saviour distributed among them the conversion and the vocation of those who once had been wrong.

It was truly necessary that all should recognise as Lord the one who died for all; and this Isaiah affirms saying: “He handed himself over to death and has been numbered among the wicked, while he bore the sins of many and interceded for sinners” (Is. 53: 12).

Responsorial. *Is. 53: 12; Lk. 23: 34*

R: He has handed himself over to death and he has been numbered among the wicked, * he was bearing the faults of many and praying all the time for sinners.

V: Jesus said: "Father, forgive them, because they do not know what they are doing":

R: He was bearing the faults of many and praying all the time for sinners.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Job 32: 1 – 6; 33: 1 – 22*

Elihu speaks of the mystery of God.

A reading from the book of Job.

So these three men ceased to answer Job, because he was righteous in his own eyes. Then Eli'hu the son of Bar'achel the Buzite, of the family of Ram, became angry. He was angry at Job because he justified himself rather than God; he was angry also at Job's three friends because they had found no answer, although they had declared Job to be in the wrong. Now Eli'hu had waited to speak to Job because they were older than he. And when Eli'hu saw that there was no answer in the mouth of these three men, he became angry.

And Eli'hu the son of Bar'achel the Buzite answered: "I am young in years, and you are aged; therefore I was timid and afraid to declare my opinion to you. "But now, hear my speech, O Job, and listen to all my words. Behold, I open my mouth; the tongue in my mouth speaks. My words declare the uprightness of my heart, and what my lips know they speak sincerely. The spirit of God has made me, and the breath of the Almighty gives me life. Answer me, if you can; set your words in order before me; take your stand. Behold, I am toward God as you are; I too was formed from a piece of clay. Behold, no fear of me need terrify you; my pressure will not be heavy upon you. "Surely, you have spoken in my hearing, and I have heard the sound of your words. You say, 'I am clean, without transgression; I am pure, and there is no iniquity in me. Behold, he finds occasions against me, he counts me as his enemy; he puts my feet in the stocks, and watches all my paths.' "Behold, in this you are not right. I

will answer you. God is greater than man. Why do you contend against him, saying, 'He will answer none of my words'? For God speaks in one way, and in two, though man does not perceive it. In a dream, in a vision of the night, when deep sleep falls upon men, while they slumber on their beds, then he opens the ears of men, and terrifies them with warnings, that he may turn man aside from his deed, and cut off pride from man; he keeps back his soul from the Pit, his life from perishing by the sword. "Man is also chastened with pain upon his bed, and with continual strife in his bones; so that his life loathes bread, and his appetite dainty food. His flesh is so wasted away that it cannot be seen; and his bones that were not seen stick out. His soul draws near the Pit, and his life to those who bring death.

Responsorial. *Rm. 11: 33, 34*

R: How rich are the depths of God, how deep his wisdom and knowledge. * How impossible it is to penetrate his judgements and how inaccessible are his ways!

V: Who has ever known the mind of the Lord? Who could ever be his counsellor?

R: How impossible it is to penetrate his judgements and how inaccessible are his ways!

Second Reading. *Book 23, 23 – 24*

The true science flees from pride.

A reading from the “Commentary on the book of Job” of St. Gregory the great, pope.

‘Job, I ask you for a hearing; now it is my time to tell you what I know’. It is a characteristic of arrogant teachers that they are unable to present their teaching modestly, that they fail to serve as they should the truths that they hold. They make it plain by their words that when they are teaching they fancy themselves seated on some lofty place of eminence and they look down on their hearers standing far below them, on the lowest level, as persons who scarcely merit their domination, not to say their concern.

The words of the Lord through the prophet are well directed at them: ‘With force and harshness you have ruled them’. For men rule with force

and harshness when they are concerned not to correct those under them by calm reasoning but to bend them by harsh domination.

Sound teaching, on the other hand, measures its earnestness in avoiding this sin of pride in thought by its eagerness to attack with its words the teacher of pride himself. It takes care not to proclaim him by an arrogant manner while it attacks him with pious words in the hearts of the hearers. It strives to preach in what it says and manifests in what it does, humility, the mistress and mother of all virtues, in order to commend this more by conduct than by words to those who are seeking the truth.

This is why Paul spoke as if he had forgotten the dignity of his own apostleship in his words to the Thessalonians: 'We were babes among you'. Similarly the apostle Peter says: 'Always be prepared to make a defence to any one who calls you to account for the hope that is in you', and he adds, to emphasise that our teaching must be presented in the proper way: 'Yet do it with gentleness and reverence; and keep your conscience clear'.

When Paul says to Titus: 'Command these things, teach them with all authority', he is not recommending the domination of power but the force of his disciple's life. A man teaches with authority what he first practises himself before preaching to others, for when conscience is an obstacle to speech, what is taught is more difficult to accept. So then Paul is not recommending the power of haughty words but the trustworthiness which comes from good conduct. Our Lord too, we are told, taught as one who had authority, and not as the scribes and the Pharisees. He alone spoke with a unique authority because he had committed no sin from weakness. It was from the power of his divinity that he possessed that which he bestowed on us through the sinlessness of his humanity.

Responsorial. *1 Pet. 5: 5; Mt. 11: 29*

R: All wrap yourselves in humility to be servants of each other, * because God refuses the proud and will always favour the humble.

V: Learn from me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls,

R: because God refuses the proud and will always favour the humble.

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 44 – 46*

He sold all his goods and bought that field.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"The kingdom of heaven is like treasure hidden in a field, which a man found and covered up; then in his joy he goes and sells all that he has and buys that field. Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a merchant in search of fine pearls, who, on finding one pearl of great value, went and sold all that he had and bought it.

THURSDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 12: 20 – 33*

Political and religious schism.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

And when all Israel heard that Jerobo'am had returned, they sent and called him to the assembly and made him king over all Israel. There was none that followed the house of David, but the tribe of Judah only.

When Rehobo'am came to Jerusalem, he assembled all the house of Judah, and the tribe of Benjamin, a hundred and eighty thousand chosen warriors, to fight against the house of Israel, to restore the kingdom to Rehobo'am the son of Solomon. But the word of God came to Shemai'ah the man of God: "Say to Rehobo'am the son of Solomon, king of Judah, and to all the house of Judah and Benjamin, and to the rest of the people, `Thus says the LORD, You shall not go up or fight against your kinsmen the people of Israel. Return every man to his home, for this thing is from me.'" So they hearkened to the word of the LORD, and went home again, according to the word of the LORD. Then Jerobo'am built Shechem in the hill country of E'phraim, and dwelt there; and he went out from there and built Penu'el. And Jerobo'am said in his heart, "Now the kingdom will turn back to the house of David; if this people go up to offer sacrifices in the house of the LORD at Jerusalem, then the heart of this people will turn again to their lord, to Rehobo'am king of Judah, and they will kill me and return to Rehobo'am king of Judah." So the king took counsel, and made two calves of gold. And he said to the people, "You have gone up to Jerusalem long enough. Behold your gods, O Israel, who brought you up out of the land of Egypt." And he set one in Bethel, and the other he put in Dan. And this thing became a sin, for the people went to the one at Bethel and to the other as far as Dan. He also made houses on high places, and appointed priests from among all the people, who were not of the Levites. And Jerobo'am appointed a feast on the fifteenth day of the eighth month like the feast that was in Judah, and he offered sacrifices upon the altar; so he did in Bethel, sacrificing to the calves that he had made. And he placed in Bethel the priests of the high places that he had made. He went up to the

altar which he had made in Bethel on the fifteenth day in the eighth month, in the month which he had devised of his own heart; and he ordained a feast for the people of Israel, and went up to the altar to burn incense.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Tob. 14: 6, 7 (Vulg. 14: 8-9); Ap. 21, 24*

R: All the people will abandon their idols; and they will come to Jerusalem and they will live in it. * Those who love God in truth will rejoice.

V: The nations will walk in his light.

R: Those who love God in truth will rejoice.

Second Reading. *Book 5, t.2*

The institution of the cult in spirit and truth by means of the oracles of the gospel.

A reading from the “Commentary on the prophet Isaiah” of St. Cyril of Alexandria, bishop.

“The Law was given through Moses, grace and truth have come through Jesus Christ” (Jn. 1: 17). He calls grace and truth the institution of the cult in spirit and truth, which came about by means of the oracles of the gospel, with great virtue and power. It was in fact suitable that Moses, being the servant, should have been the minister of a shadow destined to disappear; while he who is eternal, that is Christ, should be the one who reveals the true and everlasting cult.

In what consists then that eternal covenant, which Christ will fulfil completely in faith for those who draw near to him, he explains adding immediately: the holy promises made to David are faithful. With these words he wants to say, either that the promise of Christ saviour of us all, made to the holy David, is to be extended to the Gentiles who come to the faith; or he calls divine and sacred the prophecies regarding the Christ, who according to the flesh was born of the seed of David. He says that they are holy, since they make those who receive them holy: in the same way he calls the fear of the Lord pure because it purifies, and he calls life the announcement of the gospel which gives life. Christ in fact says: “The words that I have said to you are spirit and truth” (Jn. 6: 63), that is spiritual and vivifying.

They are therefore holy because they sanctify and make just and irreproachable those who receive them: they are also faithful because they

arouse the faith, and they establish the stability in the faith and the piety of life in those who have got to know them. This is the power and the efficacy of the prophecies regarding the Christ. When he nominated David, that is Christ born of the descendants of David according to the flesh, he said of him: “Behold I have constituted him as a witness among the peoples, prince and sovereign over the nations” (Is. 55: 4). In this way he attests that our Lord Jesus Christ gives the light of the true knowledge of God to the multitude of the people, in the measure in which they are capable of receiving it, that is by desiring it without offering resistance. He says in fact through the lyre of the psalmist: “Hear this, all nations, pay attention all who live on the earth, important people, ordinary people, rich and poor alike. My lips have a wisdom to utter, my heart whispers sound sense” (Ps. 48: 2-4). Wisdom and intelligence was very necessary to those who had done wrong, adoring with extreme thoughtlessness the creature in the place of the Creator, and calling gods pieces of wood and stones.

After all this the Word became flesh, and manifested himself in all his splendour saying to them: “The Spirit of the Lord is upon me; for this he has consecrated me with the anointing, and he has sent me to announce to the poor a good news, to proclaim liberty to the prisoners and sight to the blind, to give back freedom to those who are oppressed” (Lk. 4: 18; Is. 61: 1).

These in fact were the sicknesses of the peoples, but thanks to him they were healed. He enriched them with the gift of wisdom, and they became capable of understanding; in this way their soul was not any more sick and wounded, but healthy and capable of welcoming and carrying to fulfilment every good thing, which is necessary for salvation.

Responsorial. *Jn. 4: 23-24*

R: The true worshippers will worship the Father in spirit and truth, * because that is the kind of worshipper the Father wants.

V: God is spirit, and those who worship must worship him in spirit and truth,

R: because that is the kind of worshipper the Father wants.

First Reading. Job 38: 1 – 30

God confounds Job.

A reading from the book of Job.

Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind: "Who is this that darkens counsel by words without knowledge? Gird up your loins like a man, I will question you, and you shall declare to me. "Where were you when I laid the foundation of the earth? Tell me, if you have understanding. Who determined its measurements -- surely you know! Or who stretched the line upon it? On what were its bases sunk, or who laid its cornerstone, when the morning stars sang together, and all the sons of God shouted for joy?

"Or who shut in the sea with doors, when it burst forth from the womb; when I made clouds its garment, and thick darkness its swaddling band, and prescribed bounds for it, and set bars and doors, and said, `Thus far shall you come, and no farther, and here shall your proud waves be stayed'?

"Have you commanded the morning since your days began, and caused the dawn to know its place, that it might take hold of the skirts of the earth, and the wicked be shaken out of it? It is changed like clay under the seal, and it is dyed like a garment. From the wicked their light is withheld, and their uplifted arm is broken. "Have you entered into the springs of the sea, or walked in the recesses of the deep?

Have the gates of death been revealed to you, or have you seen the gates of deep darkness? Have you comprehended the expanse of the earth? Declare, if you know all this. "Where is the way to the dwelling of light, and where is the place of darkness, that you may take it to its territory and that you may discern the paths to its home? You know, for you were born then, and the number of your days is great! "Have you entered the storehouses of the snow, or have you seen the storehouses of the hail, which I have reserved for the time of trouble, for the day of battle and war? What is the way to the place where the light is distributed, or where the east wind is scattered upon the earth? "Who has cleft a channel for the torrents of rain, and a way for the thunderbolt, to bring rain on a land where no man is, on the desert in which there is no man; to satisfy the waste and desolate land, and to make the ground put forth grass? "Has the rain a father, or who has begotten the drops of dew? From whose womb did the ice come forth, and

who has given birth to the hoarfrost of heaven? The waters become hard like stone, and the face of the deep is frozen.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Jb. 38: 3; Rm. 9: 20*

R: Gird your loins like a man, I will question you and you will answer me.

*O man, who are you to dispute with God?

V: Does the pot dare to say to the potter: Why did you make me this shape?

R: O man, who are you to dispute with God?

Second Reading. *Book 29: 2 – 4*

The Church advances as a dawn that rises.

A reading from the “Commentary on the book of Job” of St. Gregory the Great, pope.

Because the dawn, or day-spring, changes from darkness into light, it is right to understand by the name ‘dawn’ or ‘day-spring’ the whole Church of the elect. While it is brought from the night of unbelief to the light of faith, it is opened up to the splendour of heavenly brightness, as the dawn bursts into day after the darkness. The words of the Song of Songs are to the point: ‘Who is she who comes forth as the rising dawn? Holy Church, seeking for the rewards of the heavenly life, is called the dawn because it leaves the darkness of sin and shines with the light of holiness.

We have a deeper point to examine, after considering the nature of the dawn. Dawn announces that night has already passed, but it does not display the full brightness of day; while it is dispelling the one it is welcoming the other, and it keeps light and darkness intermingled. **All of us who follow the truth, what are we in this life, if not ‘dawn’ or ‘day-spring’? We do some things that are of the light, but we are still not free from some remains of the darkness.** The prophet said to God: ‘No man living is righteous before you’, and another text reads: ‘All of us do wrong in many ways’.

When Paul said: ‘The night is far gone’, he did not add: ‘The day has come’, but, ‘The day is at hand’. He who says, after night has gone, not that the day ‘has arrived’ but that it is ‘at hand’, shows beyond doubt that he is still in the dawn, before the sun and after the darkness.

The Church of the elect will be fully day only when the darkness of sin is no longer blended with it. It will be fully day only when it has been brightened with the perfect warmth of the inward light. The fact that this dawn is still in course is brought out well by the words, 'You have sent the dawn to its place'. What is being sent to its place is certainly being called out of one state into another. What is the place of the dawn but the perfect brightness of the eternal vision? When it has arrived there it has no longer any of the darkness of the past night. The dawn was intent on reaching its place when David said: 'My soul thirsts for the living God; when shall I come and appear before the face of God?' The dawn was hurrying to this place, which it had known, when Paul said that he desired to die and be with Christ, and when he said: 'For me to live is Christ, and to die is gain'.

Responsorial. *Phil 1: 3, 6, 9*

R: I thank my God whenever I think of you. * I am quite certain that the One who began this good work in you will see that it is finished when the Day of Christ Jesus comes.

V: This is my prayer, that your love may grow ever richer and richer in knowledge and insight of every kind.

R: I am quite certain that the One who began this good work in you will see that it is finished when the Day of Christ Jesus comes.

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 47 – 53*

They will collect the good in baskets and throw away the wicked.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

"Again, the kingdom of heaven is like a net which was thrown into the sea and gathered fish of every kind; when it was full, men drew it ashore and sat down and sorted the good into vessels but threw away the bad. So it will be at the close of the age. The angels will come out and separate the evil from the righteous, and throw them into the furnace of fire; there men will weep and gnash their teeth. "Have you understood all this?" They said to him, "Yes."

And he said to them, "Therefore every scribe who has been trained for the kingdom of heaven is like a householder who brings out of his treasure what is new and what is old." And when Jesus had finished these parables, he went away from there.

FRIDAY

CYCLE 1

First Letter. *1 Kings 16: 29 – 17: 16*

The prophet Elijah, at the time of Ahab, king of Israel.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

In the thirty-eighth year of Asa king of Judah, Ahab the son of Omri began to reign over Israel, and Ahab the son of Omri reigned over Israel in Sama'ria twenty-two years. And Ahab the son of Omri did evil in the sight of the LORD more than all that were before him. And as if it had been a light thing for him to walk in the sins of Jerobo'am the son of Nebat, he took for wife Jez'ebel the daughter of Ethba'al king of the Sido'nians, and went and served Ba'al, and worshiped him. He erected an altar for Ba'al in the house of Ba'al, which he built in Sama'ria. And Ahab made an Ashe'rah. Ahab did more to provoke the LORD, the God of Israel, to anger than all the kings of Israel who were before him.

In his days Hi'el of Bethel built Jericho; he laid its foundation at the cost of Abi'ram his first-born, and set up its gates at the cost of his youngest son Segub, according to the word of the LORD, which he spoke by Joshua the son of Nun. Now Eli'jah the Tishbite, of Tishbe in Gilead, said to Ahab, "As the LORD the God of Israel lives, before whom I stand, there shall be neither dew nor rain these years, except by my word." And the word of the LORD came to him, "Depart from here and turn eastward, and hide yourself by the brook Cherith, that is east of the Jordan. You shall drink from the brook, and I have commanded the ravens to feed you there." So he went and did according to the word of the LORD; he went and dwelt by the brook Cherith that is east of the Jordan. And the ravens brought him bread and meat in the morning, and bread and meat in the evening; and he drank from the brook. And after a while the brook dried up, because there was no rain in the land.

Then the word of the LORD came to him, "Arise, go to Zar'ephath, which belongs to Sidon, and dwell there. Behold, I have commanded a widow there to feed you." So he arose and went to Zar'ephath; and when he came to the gate of the city, behold, a widow was there gathering sticks; and he called to her and said, "Bring me a little water in a vessel, that I may

drink." And as she was going to bring it, he called to her and said, "Bring me a morsel of bread in your hand." And she said, "As the LORD your God lives, I have nothing baked, only a handful of meal in a jar, and a little oil in a cruse; and now, I am gathering a couple of sticks, that I may go in and prepare it for myself and my son, that we may eat it, and die." And Eli'jah said to her, "Fear not; go and do as you have said; but first make me a little cake of it and bring it to me, and afterward make for yourself and your son. For thus says the LORD the God of Israel, 'The jar of meal shall not be spent, and the cruse of oil shall not fail, until the day that the LORD sends rain upon the earth.'" And she went and did as Eli'jah said; and she, and he, and her household ate for many days. The jar of meal was not spent, neither did the cruse of oil fail, according to the word of the LORD which he spoke by Eli'jah.

Responsorial. *GC 5; 17-18; Sir. 48: 1, 3*

R. Elijah prayed intensely for it not to rain, and it did not rain; * he then prayed again, and the heavens gave forth rain.

V: Then the prophet Elijah arose like a fire, his word flaring like a torch. By the word of the Lord he shut up the heavens.

R: he then prayed again, and the heavens gave forth rain.

Second Reading. *Nm 1 – 7*

Catechesis on the pre- baptismal rites.

Beginning of the "Treatise on the mysteries" of St. Ambrose, bishop.

We have spoken daily upon subjects connected with morals, when the deeds of the Patriarchs or the precepts of the Proverbs were being read, in order that being taught and instructed by these you might grow accustomed to enter the ways of the ancients and to walk in their paths, and obey the divine commands; in order that being renewed by baptism you might hold to that manner of life which suits those who are washed.

The season now warns us to speak of the Mysteries, and to set forth the nature of the sacraments, which if we had thought it well to teach before baptism to those who were not yet initiated, we should be considered rather to have betrayed than to have portrayed the Mysteries. And then, too,

another reason is that the light itself of the Mysteries will shed itself with more effect upon those who are expecting they know not what, than if any discourse had come beforehand.

Open, then, your ears, inhale the good savour of eternal life which has been breathed upon you by the grace of the sacraments; which was signified to you by us, when, celebrating the mystery of the opening, we said, “Epphatha, which is, Be opened,” that whosoever was coming in quest of peace might know what he was asked, and be bound to remember what he answered. Christ made use of this mystery in the Gospel, as we read, when He healed him who was deaf and dumb.

After this the Holy of holies was opened to you, you entered the sanctuary of regeneration; recall what you were asked, and remember what you answered. You renounced the devil and his works, the world with its luxury and pleasures. That utterance of yours is preserved not in the tombs of the dead, but in the book of the living. You saw there the deacon, you saw the priest, you saw the chief priest [i.e. the bishop]. Consider not the bodily forms, but the grace of the Mysteries. You spoke in the presence of the angels, as it is written: “For the priest’s lips keep knowledge, and they seek the law at his mouth, for he is the angel of the Lord Almighty.” There is no place for deception nor for denial. He is an angel who proclaims the kingdom of Christ and eternal life. He is to be esteemed by you not according to his appearance, but according to his office. Consider what he delivered, reflect upon the rule of life he gave you, recognize his position. You entered, then, that you might discern your adversary, whom you were to renounce as it were to his face, then you turned to the east; for he who renounces the devil turns to Christ, and beholds Him face to face.

Responsorial. *Cfr. Tt. 3: 3, 5; Ep. 2: 3*

R: Remember there was a time when we too were ignorant, living in wickedness and in jealousy, hating each other and hating ourselves. * But God saved us through the cleansing water of rebirth in the Holy Spirit.

V: All of us, at one time followed the desires of the flesh, by nature we merited the divine anger.

R: But God saved us through the cleansing water of rebirth in the Holy Spirit.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Job 40: 1 – 14; 42: 1 – 6*

Job submits to the greatness of God.

A reading from the book of Job.

And the LORD said to Job: "Shall a faultfinder contend with the Almighty? He who argues with God, let him answer it." Then Job answered the LORD: "Behold, I am of small account; what shall I answer you? I lay my hand on my mouth. I have spoken once, and I will not answer; twice, but I will proceed no further."

Then the LORD answered Job out of the whirlwind: "Gird up your loins like a man; I will question you, and you declare to me. Will you even put me in the wrong? Will you condemn me that you may be justified? Have you an arm like God, and can you thunder with a voice like his? "Deck yourself with majesty and dignity; clothe yourself with glory and splendour. Pour forth the overflowing of your anger, and look on every one that is proud, and abase him. Look on every one that is proud, and bring him low; and tread down the wicked where they stand. Hide them all in the dust together; bind their faces in the world below. Then will I also acknowledge to you, that your own right hand can give you victory.

Then Job answered the LORD: "I know that you can do all things, and that no purpose of yours can be thwarted. 'Who is this that hides counsel without knowledge?' Therefore I have uttered what I did not understand, things too wonderful for me, which I did not know. 'Hear, and I will speak; I will question you, and you declare to me.' I had heard of you by the hearing of the ear, but now my eye sees you; therefore I despise myself, and repent in dust and ashes."

Responsorial. *Jb. 42: 5-6; 40: 5, 4*

R: I knew you then only by hearsay, Lord; now my eyes see you, I retract all I have said, * and in dust and ashes I repent.

V: I have spoken once, and I will not speak again; I have spoken twice, but I will not continue. I will put my hand over my mouth,

R: and in dust and ashes I repent.

Second Reading. *Treatise 6*

The Lord discerns the thoughts and the intentions of the heart.
A reading from the “Treatises” of Baldwin of Canterbury, bishop.

The Lord knows the thoughts and intentions of our hearts. It is certain that he knows them all, whilst we can only evaluate those he has let us discern by the grace of discernment. But the spirit of man, which is in man, does not know all that is in man nor can it see for what they really are the thoughts that he feels willingly or unwillingly. And even those things that he sees right before the eyes of the mind he cannot accurately discern through the cloudiness of his mental vision.

Often, either on his own initiative or influenced by man or by the Tempter, he takes a course of action that has the appearance of being good, but which in the eyes of God does not deserve the reward of virtue. For there are counterfeits of the true virtues and also of the vices which deceive the eyes of the heart and hoodwink the vision of the mind, by means of a certain trickery, so that often there seems to be an appearance of good in what is actually not good and an appearance of evil in what is good. This is all part of our wretchedness and ignorance that we should deeply lament and greatly fear.

It is written, ‘There are ways that seem right to a man, but their end is the way to death’. Saint John warns us about avoiding that danger when he says, ‘Test the spirits to see whether they are of God’. But who can test the spirits to see whether they are of God unless God gives him the discernment of spirits to enable him to examine accurately and with true judgement spiritual thoughts, movements and intentions? Indeed, discernment is the mother of all virtues, and is herself essential to each of them, whether in the directing of someone else’s life or in the direction or amendment of one’s own.

A thought about doing something is right when it is governed by God’s will; and that intention is truly religious that is directed straight to him in simplicity of heart. Just so, if our eye is sound the whole body of our life, or of any of our actions, will be full of light. A sound eye is both an eye and sound, because it sees what is to be done with a right mind and does soundly with a religious intention what is not to be done in a way that is not sound. Right thought admits no error; a religious intention excludes falseness. And this conjunction of right thought and virtuous intention is true discernment.

Hence all things are to be done in the light of discernment, as in God and before his presence.

Responsorial. *Mic. 6: 8; Ps. 36: 3*

R: The Lord has shown you, O man, what is good; * and what does the Lord require of you, but to do justice, to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God.

V: If you trust in the Lord and do good, then you will live in the land;

R: and what does the Lord require of you, but to do justice, to love kindness, and to walk humbly with your God.

Gospel. *Mt. 13: 54 – 58*

Is this not the son of the carpenter?

From where has he learnt all these things.

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

And coming to his own country he taught them in their synagogue, so that they were astonished, and said, "Where did this man get this wisdom and these mighty works? Is not this the carpenter's son? Is not his mother called Mary? And are not his brothers James and Joseph and Simon and Judas? And are not all his sisters with us? Where then did this man get all this?" And they took offence at him. But Jesus said to them, "A prophet is not without honour except in his own country and in his own house." And he did not do many mighty works there, because of their unbelief.

SATURDAY

CYCLE 1

First Reading. *1 Kings 18: 16b – 40*

Elijah wins the challenge against the priests of Baal.

A reading from the first book of Kings.

So Obadi'ah went to meet Ahab, and told him; and Ahab went to meet Eli'jah. When Ahab saw Eli'jah, Ahab said to him, "Is it you, you troubler of Israel?" And he answered, "I have not troubled Israel; but you have, and your father's house, because you have forsaken the commandments of the LORD and followed the Ba'als. Now therefore send and gather all Israel to me at Mount Carmel, and the four hundred and fifty prophets of Ba'al and the four hundred prophets of Ashe'rah, who eat at Jez'ebel's table." So Ahab sent to all the people of Israel, and gathered the prophets together at Mount Carmel. And Eli'jah came near to all the people, and said, "How long will you go limping with two different opinions? If the LORD is God, follow him; but if Ba'al, then follow him." And the people did not answer him a word. Then Eli'jah said to the people, "I, even I only, am left a prophet of the LORD; but Ba'al's prophets are four hundred and fifty men. Let two bulls be given to us; and let them choose one bull for themselves, and cut it in pieces and lay it on the wood, but put no fire to it; and I will prepare the other bull and lay it on the wood, and put no fire to it. And you call on the name of your god and I will call on the name of the LORD; and the God who answers by fire, he is God." And all the people answered, "It is well spoken."

Then Eli'jah said to the prophets of Ba'al, "Choose for yourselves one bull and prepare it first, for you are many; and call on the name of your god, but put no fire to it." And they took the bull which was given them, and they prepared it, and called on the name of Ba'al from morning until noon, saying, "O Ba'al, answer us!" But there was no voice, and no one answered. And they limped about the altar that they had made. And at noon Eli'jah mocked them, saying, "Cry aloud, for he is a god; either he is musing, or he has gone aside, or he is on a journey, or perhaps he is asleep and must be awakened." And they cried aloud, and cut themselves after their custom with swords and lances, until the blood gushed out upon them. And as

midday passed, they raved on until the time of the offering of the oblation, but there was no voice; no one answered, no one heeded.

Then Eli'jah said to all the people, "Come near to me"; and all the people came near to him. And he repaired the altar of the LORD that had been thrown down; Eli'jah took twelve stones, according to the number of the tribes of the sons of Jacob, to whom the word of the LORD came, saying, "Israel shall be your name"; and with the stones he built an altar in the name of the LORD. And he made a trench about the altar, as great as would contain two measures of seed. And he put the wood in order, and cut the bull in pieces and laid it on the wood. And he said, "Fill four jars with water, and pour it on the burnt offering, and on the wood." And he said, "Do it a second time"; and they did it a second time. And he said, "Do it a third time"; and they did it a third time. And the water ran round about the altar, and filled the trench also with water. And at the time of the offering of the oblation, Eli'jah the prophet came near and said, "O LORD, God of Abraham, Isaac, and Israel, let it be known this day that you are God in Israel, and that I am your servant, and that I have done all these things at your word. Answer me, O LORD, answer me, that this people may know that you, O LORD, are God, and that you have turned their hearts back." Then the fire of the LORD fell, and consumed the burnt offering, and the wood, and the stones, and the dust, and licked up the water that was in the trench. And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces; and they said, "The LORD, he is God; the LORD, he is God." And Eli'jah said to them, "Seize the prophets of Ba'al; let not one of them escape." And they seized them; and Eli'jah brought them down to the brook Kishon, and killed them there.

Responsorial. *1 Kg. 18: 21; Mt. 6: 24*

R: Elijah said to all he people: until when will you go limping with two different opinions? * If the Lord is God, follow him!

V: No one can serve two masters: You cannot serve God and money.

R: If the Lord is God, follow him!

Second Reading. *Nm. 8 – 11*

Rebirth from water and the Holy Spirit.

A reading from the “Treatise on the mysteries” of St. Ambrose, bishop.

What did you see? Water, certainly, but not water alone; you saw the deacons ministering there, and the bishop asking questions and consecrating. First of all, the Apostle taught you that those things are not to be considered “which we see, but the things that are not seen, for the things that are seen are temporal, but the things that are not seen are eternal.” For you read elsewhere: “That the invisible things of God, since the creation of the world, are understood through those things which have been made; His eternal power also and Godhead are estimated by His works.” Wherefore also the Lord Himself says: “If you believe not me, believe at least the works.” Believe, then, that the presence of the Godhead is there. Do you believe the working, and not believe the presence? Whence should the working proceed unless the presence went before? Consider, however, how ancient is the mystery prefigured even in the origin of the world itself. In the very beginning, when God made the heaven and the earth, “the Spirit,” it is said, “moved upon the waters.” He who was moving upon the waters, was He not working upon the waters? But why should I say, “working”? As regards His presence He was moving. Was He not working who was moving? Recognize that He was working in that making of the world, when the prophet says: “By the word of the Lord were the heavens made, and all their strength by the spirit of His mouth.” Each statement rests upon the testimony of the prophet, both that He was moving and that He was working. Moses says that He was moving, David testifies that he was working. Take another testimony. All flesh was corrupt by its iniquities. “My Spirit,” says God, “shall not remain among men, because they are flesh.” Whereby God shows that the grace of the Spirit is turned away by carnal impurity and the pollution of grave sin. Upon which, God, willing to restore what was lacking, sent the flood and bade just Noah go up into the ark. And he, after having (as the flood was receding) sent forth first a raven which did not return, sent forth a dove which is said to have returned with an olive twig. You see the water, you see the wood [of the ark], you see the dove, and do you hesitate as to the mystery? The water, then, is that in which the flesh is dipped, that all carnal sin may be washed away. All wickedness is there buried. The wood is that on which the Lord Jesus was fastened when He suffered for us. The dove is that in the form of which the Holy Spirit descended, as you have read in the New Testament, Who inspires in you peace of soul and tranquillity of mind. The raven is the

figure of sin, which goes forth and does not return, if, in you, too, inwardly and outwardly righteousness be preserved.

Responsorial. *Is. 44: 3, 4; Jn. 4: 14*

R: For I will pour out water on thirsty soil, torrents on dry ground. I will pour out my Spirit, * they will grow like poplars by running streams.

V: The water that I will give will become a spring of water that gushes for eternal life;

R: they will grow like poplars by running streams.

CYCLE 2

First Reading. *Job 42: 7 – 17*

God recognizes the justice of Job and rewards him in front of his friends.

A reading from the book of Job.

After the LORD had spoken these words to Job, the LORD said to Eli'phaz the Te'manite: "My wrath is kindled against you and against your two friends; for you have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has. Now therefore take seven bulls and seven rams, and go to my servant Job, and offer up for yourselves a burnt offering; and my servant Job shall pray for you, for I will accept his prayer not to deal with you according to your folly; for you have not spoken of me what is right, as my servant Job has."

So Eli'phaz the Te'manite and Bildad the Shuhite and Zophar the Na'amathite went and did what the LORD had told them; and the LORD accepted Job's prayer. And the LORD restored the fortunes of Job, when he had prayed for his friends; and the LORD gave Job twice as much as he had before. Then came to him all his brothers and sisters and all who had known him before, and ate bread with him in his house; and they showed him sympathy and comforted him for all the evil that the LORD had brought upon him; and each of them gave him a piece of money and a ring of gold.

And the LORD blessed the latter days of Job more than his beginning; and he had fourteen thousand sheep, six thousand camels, a thousand yoke of oxen, and a thousand she-asses. He had also seven sons and three daughters. And he called the name of the first Jemi'mah; and the name of

the second Kezi'ah; and the name of the third Ker'en-hap'puch. And in all the land there were no women so fair as Job's daughters; and their father gave them inheritance among their brothers.

And after this Job lived a hundred and forty years, and saw his sons, and his sons' sons, four generations. And Job died, an old man, and full of days.

Responsorial. *Jb. 42: 10, 11, 12; 1 Cor. 10: 13*

R: The Lord gave Job twice as much as he had before and his brothers consoled him. * The Lord blessed Job more than before.

V: God is faithful: he does not permit you to be tempted beyond your strength, but with the temptation he will also give you the way out.

R: The Lord blessed Job more than before.

Second Reading. *C. 14, Lett. 2*

The way to arrive at the true life.

A reading from the “Exposition on John” of St. Thomas Aquinas, presbyter.

Christ himself is the way, and hence he says: ‘I am the way’. And good reason he had for saying so, since through him we have access to the Father.

Now, because this way is not at a distance from its terminating point but rather joined with it, he adds, ‘the truth and the life’, and so he is at once the way and its termination. In his humanity he is the way, in his divinity the termination. So, as man he says, ‘I am the way’, and as God he adds, ‘the truth and the life’, two words that well describe the termination of the way.

For the termination of this way is the realisation of our human longings. Now, man longs for two things above all: first, the knowledge of truth, which is proper to him alone, and second, the continuance of his existence, which is common to all created things. Christ is, however, the way to reach the knowledge of truth, since he is himself the truth: ‘Lead me, Lord, in truth, and I shall walk in your way’. Christ is also the way to reach life since he is himself the way: ‘You have made known paths of life’. Thus he has designated the termination of the way in terms of truth and life, both of which were used above of Christ. First, that he himself is life, hence ‘in

him was life'; then that he is truth because 'he was the light of men' and light is truth.

If, then, you seek to know what path to follow, take Christ because he is the way: 'This is the way, walk in it'. Augustine, too, has this to say: 'Walk in the way and you will arrive at God'. Now, it is better to limp in the way than to make good speed besides the way. For he who limps in the way, even though he makes little progress, draws nearer to the destination; whereas he who walks away from the way gets further from the destination the faster he runs.

If you seek to know where you are going stay close to Christ, because he is the truth that we long to reach: 'For my mouth will utter truth'. If you seek to know where you can stay, stay close to Christ, because he is the way: 'He who finds me finds life, and obtains favour from the Lord'.

Therefore stay close to Christ if you want to be secure. You will not be able to stray from the way since he is the way. Hence, those who stay close to him, walk not by devious ways but along the straight way. He cannot deceive because he is the truth and teaches all truth, as he said: 'For this was I born, and for this I have come into the world, to bear witness to the truth'. In the same way he cannot be made insecure because he is life and life giving, as he said: 'I am come that they may have life, and have it abundantly'.

Responsorial. *Ps. 85: 11; Jn. 14: 6; Ps. 15: 11*

R: Show me, Lord, your way, so that I may walk in your truth. * I am the way, the truth and the life.

V: You will show me the path of life, fullness of joy in your presence.

R: I am the way, the truth and the life.

Gospel. *Mt. 14: 1 – 12*

*Herod sends to behead John
And his disciples go to inform Jesus.*

A reading from the Gospel of St. Matthew.

At that time Herod the tetrarch heard about the fame of Jesus; and he said to his servants, "This is John the Baptist, he has been raised from the dead; that is why these powers are at work in him." For Herod had seized John and bound him and put him in prison, for the sake of Hero'di-as, his

brother Philip's wife; because John said to him, "It is not lawful for you to have her." And though he wanted to put him to death, he feared the people, because they held him to be a prophet.

But when Herod's birthday came, the daughter of Hero'di-as danced before the company, and pleased Herod, so that he promised with an oath to give her whatever she might ask. Prompted by her mother, she said, "Give me the head of John the Baptist here on a platter." And the king was sorry; but because of his oaths and his guests he commanded it to be given; he sent and had John beheaded in the prison, and his head was brought on a platter and given to the girl, and she brought it to her mother.

And his disciples came and took the body and buried it; and they went and told Jesus.